



and better positioned in the Pro League. Others, including Salima Tete and Sangita, remained quick but if they managed to run riot against the Asian sides in the ACT, the games against the likes of Netherlands and Australia proved they have a long way to go. It will only get tougher going forward but hopefully, they would have realised it as well.

Of course, the ending was climactic — but it was not as surprising as one would have thought. The women's team's failure to make the Paris cut — first at Hangzhou and then at home in Ranchi, where

everything from rankings to crowd support to home conditions were in their favour — had already put a target on Janneke's back. The coach only pre-empted what was expected to happen, perhaps after the European leg of the competition. That doesn't make it any easier for the girls, especially the senior players in the side, who now have an uncertain future.

At the end of it, the Indian men are currently placed third in the nine-team competition with 15 points from eight games. They are behind Netherlands on top with 26 points from 12 matches and Australia with 20 from eight. With two of the four teams the Indian men played against here — Australia and Ireland — present in the same pool at Paris, it

Problems aplenty: While the men boast of perhaps the biggest bench in drag-flick, the women's cupboard lies bare, with Gurjit a shadow of her old self and Deepika (in pic, No. 55) not yet there. BISWARANJAN ROUT

helped the team management work out its strategies.

The women are sixth — ahead of USA, Belgium and Great Britain at the moment — but are also the only team that, come July, will not be present at the Olympics. The women will now go home, or to training, waiting for a new coach till the European leg of the Pro League before returning to the drawing board, hoping for a fresh start post Olympics.

The Pro League, in widely different ways, was both the beginning and the end — for the men and the women respectively — of different journeys that may well transform Indian hockey over the next few months.



BISWARANJAN ROUT